



AMERICA IS GOD'S CRUCIBLE, THE GREAT MELTING POT

THE OPENING OF ELLIS ISLAND (1892)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Mass migration and population growth

BEFORE

1840s The Irish potato famine leads to mass emigration.

1848 The failure of liberal revolutions sparks large-scale German emigration.

c. 1870 Major emigration of Jews from Russia begins as they flee persecution.

1882 Restrictions are placed on the entry of Chinese into the United States.

1880s Mass emigration from Italy begins.

AFTER

1900 The population of Europe reaches 408 million; the United States, 76 million.

1907 The largest number of immigrants in a single year enters the United States: more than 1 million.

1954 Ellis Island closes.

By the mid-19th century, the world was experiencing an unprecedented boom in population, particularly in Europe. This increase would continue into the 20th century and beyond. It was partly due to improvements in health, backed by

Industrialization, urban growth, and lower infant mortality **boost European populations.**

Political and religious freedoms and **economic opportunities** in young countries such as the US attract **millions of immigrants.**

Steamships make **ocean voyages** to distant lands **safer, faster, and cheaper.**

An immigration station on Ellis Island opens to process arrivals to the United States.

more ready access to food as a consequence of improved agricultural methods. It was also a result of industrialization and urban growth, as well as the affluence and improved living standards that both produced. Political stability played a role, too. After the defeat of Napoleon in 1815, Europe enjoyed almost 100 years of largely unbroken peace.

Nature also had a hand in the increase in migration. The Irish potato famine of the 1840s, resulting from a failed crop, may have been the last major European famine, but it brought suffering on a startling scale: up to 1 million people died. It provoked among survivors a vast wave of emigration